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Ticket Escalation Process: The Ultimate Guide to Efficient Issue Resolution



Navigate the ticket escalation process like a pro! Our detailed guide covers everything from escalation stages to overcoming common challenges.

📅 January 8, 2025

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crucial, and more. Let's get started.

Salesforce found that **79% of customers want consistency in their interactions** with customer service teams. However, 55% stated that it usually feels like they're communicating with separate departments, instead of a single team aiming to resolve their ticket with as little friction as possible.

This is why your ticket escalation process needs to be as smooth, streamlined, and effective as possible. There should be a clear and defined process to move the ticket to someone better equipped to provide a resolution.

For **internal tickets**, for example, any delay in finding the solution to the user's issue damages productivity. If you can escalate the ticket efficiently, this person will be able to get back to work sooner.

This article explores the different types of ticket escalation, the reasons to escalate a ticket, and the steps you can take to produce an effective process for your stakeholders.

What exactly is ticket escalation?

Ticket escalation is a process in **customer support** and IT service management, where an issue is passed to a team or individual better equipped

days

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provide the necessary help.

The escalation process ensures that concerns, queries, and problems are handled as efficiently and comprehensively as possible.

There are categories of ticket escalation. They include:

Type of escalation	Explanation
Functional escalation	When the initial customer support agent transfers the ticket to a person or department with the skills or specialized knowledge to resolve the issue.
Hierarchical escalation	When the issue requires a higher level of authority or more experienced agent to manage and resolve.
Automatic escalation	Tickets on certain subjects, from specific individuals or companies, or based on another type of predefined criteria, immediately transfer beyond Tier 1 support.
Service-level agreement (SLA) escalation	Certain issues are dealt with as priorities, depending on the seriousness of the problem. The SLA dictates the expected resolution period for various issues, so it is important that support recognizes this hierarchy.



escalation

ticket internally, you may need to engage a third party, such as a vendor.

When should a ticket be escalated?

A ticket should be escalated when:

- **The Tier 1 agent lacks the expertise or resources:** If the agent does not possess the necessary knowledge or access to resources to resolve the issue, they will pass the query to another team or individual with the authority and decision-making power to handle it. This often involves escalating to someone who can offer discounts on subscription fees or a developer familiar with the error the customer is encountering.
- **Time constraints and workload management:** When an issue cannot be resolved quickly, it's essential to free up the Tier 1 agent to manage other incoming tickets. Many companies set time limits on how long an agent should spend on a ticket before escalating it to ensure frontline agents focus on new queries. This ensures that customer service remains efficient without agents spending excessive time on complex issues.
- **Critical or widespread impact:** If the problem is complex and could affect multiple customers, it needs to be escalated to a specialized team urgently. For example, if a bank's customers are reporting incorrect



to the app development team to prevent widespread disruption.

- **Escalation due to priority level:**

Some tickets may need to be escalated based on priority level rather than complexity. Issues that affect key clients, involve compliance risks, or could result in significant revenue loss should be escalated faster, even if they could technically be solved at a lower level.

- **When the client requests**

escalation: Sometimes, even if the Tier 1 agent has the ability to resolve the issue, the customer may request that their concern be handled by a higher-level representative. This often happens when the customer feels their issue is urgent or requires special attention.

- **Unresponsive third-party**

involvement: When an issue involves third-party vendors or integrations and the vendor becomes unresponsive, escalating to a senior team or manager who has more authority to push for a response can expedite resolution.

- **When the ticket exceeds SLA limits:**

Many service agreements have specified timelines for ticket resolution (Service Level Agreements - SLAs). If the issue is approaching or exceeding the agreed-upon SLA time, it should be escalated to ensure compliance and avoid customer dissatisfaction.

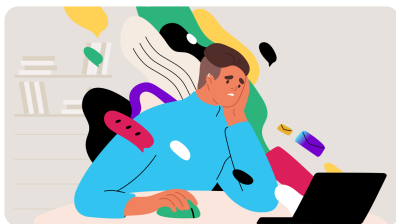
- **Security concerns or data**

breaches: Any issue related to security, such as potential data



Escalated immediately to ensure swift action by the security or IT team. The frontline agent should never attempt to handle such issues alone.

- **When resolution requires specific permissions:** In cases where resolving the issue requires permissions or actions that the Tier 1 agent does not have, such as modifying account settings, accessing confidential information, or processing financial transactions, the ticket should be escalated to someone with the necessary permissions.
- **When the resolution requires cross-department collaboration:** Some issues may span multiple departments (e.g., finance, technical support, and sales). If the Tier 1 agent cannot coordinate effectively across departments, escalation to a manager or a designated point person may be necessary to ensure the issue is addressed holistically.



Steps to an effective ticket escalation process



This will automate the process of escalation, providing consistency in [the way you deal with tickets](#). For example, it could be that all tickets relating to one particular area of the company are always escalated. But it might also be that tickets trigger escalation when they are unresolved for a set amount of time, or when they meet thresholds for importance or complexity.

2. Categorize your ticket priorities

To help understand which customer issues require additional input, designate them with a priority level (e.g. low, medium, high). This makes it easier to understand which should be escalated and when.

3. Designate escalation tiers

Understanding where the ticket goes next is key to a smooth and effective process. Create multiple support tiers so that each issue can be sent to the appropriate place rather than simply passing up the chain and out of the previous agent's hands. Tier 1 is generally basic level support. Tier 2 might be technical specialists, Tier 3 could be management, and so on.

4. Request agents to replicate issues



controlled environment. They should mimic the exact steps or conditions that led to the customer's issue, which will help them designate the correct tier of support to which they should direct their ticket.

5. Set response time SLAs

By setting out the time limits for each tier of support to resolve a ticket in an SLA, you give the customer a clear idea of when their problem will be addressed and help to manage the time of your internal stakeholders more effectively. They understand how long they should spend before escalating.

6. Automate escalation workflow

Use a [customer ticketing system](#) to take the manual process out of escalation based on time limits, [category](#), [tag](#), or other criteria. By setting parameters, you can ensure the ticket makes its way as soon as you hit the SLA time limit for its current tier, for example.

7. Train support teams

Make sure that all agents understand the process for escalating tickets and the reasoning behind it. This will help them decide on the best course of action to take during their working day. Document the process and make it available to them through a shared



Tips to improve your ticket escalation process

- **Help other team members understand the context of the ticket** by using a conversational platform to capture your tickets. When [users start tickets in Slack](#), Discord, or other such programs, they tend to provide more contextual detail about the issue, which can help the team to which the ticket is escalated.
- **Build a solid knowledge base** for your agents to refer to when they receive a support query. This allows them to resolve more issues independently and reduce the need to escalate tickets.
- **Review your escalation history** to identify patterns and recurring customer issues. This will help you hone your process and reduce the amount of time spent on customer queries and instances of escalation.
- **Ensure that your escalation process** is the same for all communication channels. You need a consistent approach that provides the same level of service no matter how users access support.
- **Train your team in soft skills** to enable them to handle interactions with empathy and professionalism. This will improve the customer experience and help them feel informed and valued as the issue



- **Encourage better cross-department collaboration** to address complex tickets more effectively. By working together using internal communication channels like Slack, rather than in siloes, you ensure the consistency that customers crave is delivered.
- **Empower Tier 1 support** with more authority and additional tools that allow them to resolve more issues quickly and without the need to escalate them to another level.
- **Use AI and automation** to speed up the process of support, handling recurring problems, and answering common questions with features such as ticket deflection. This means your human customer support team is better able to work on more complex problems.

Common challenges in the ticket escalation process

Challenge

Explanation

Inadequate prioritization

Tickets can often be escalated without the right prioritization, leading to delays in addressing critical issues. Without being clear about the hierarchy of customer tickets, support teams might struggle to identify the most urgent problems and spend time on



Workflow complexity

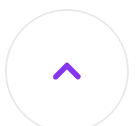
There are multiple teams that can be involved with the escalation process. This means that everyone needs to understand the workflow so they can better organize their time. Without a streamlined ticketing process, agents could get confused over who needs to take charge of certain tickets.

Escalation bottlenecks

If you have high escalation rates, it can create bottlenecks in the workflow of your Tier 2 and Tier 3 agents. This suggests that Tier 1 is not equipped to deal with tasks that really should not need escalation to higher-level support agents. This may be due to inadequate training or a poorly configured system.

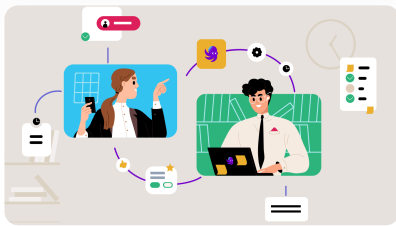
Lack of integration

The [ticketing system](#) needs to be implanted in the places where your team spends their time. This means integrating it with communication tools like Slack. If not, they spend their time switching between apps, with the risk that tickets will fall through the cracks. Other benefits are that conversational platforms like Slack retain more of the context of the issue at hand and you maintain the interaction with the client in the same chat, displaying transparency through the process. Wrangle allows companies



Insufficient reporting

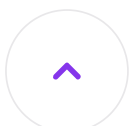
The best way to improve your customer support ticket escalation process and reduce the rate of escalation is to analyze the data on it. If you do not have access to detailed reporting, you will find it difficult to address recurring issues and areas of improvement.



FAQ

When does escalation happen in the workflow?

The escalation might happen initially during ticket triage, if the person in charge decides that the issue requires a higher level of seniority or specialist knowledge to resolve. Otherwise, an [agent may try to resolve it](#), before escalating if they cannot help or run out of time. At this later stage of escalation, using a platform like Slack might help. The conversational nature of the platform allows the new agent to find out more about the problem and the previous attempts to sort it out.



An agent should thoroughly understand the customer's issue, attempt to replicate it if possible, consult internal knowledge bases for solutions, and document all relevant information before escalating the ticket.

Is there a maximum number of times a ticket can be escalated?

Typically, there's no strict maximum number of escalations, but organizations aim to minimize escalations by resolving issues at the appropriate level to maintain efficiency and customer satisfaction. An efficient resolution should take place with as few escalations as possible or risk ending in customer frustration.

What should an agent do if an escalation does not resolve the issue?

If an escalation doesn't resolve the issue, the agent should coordinate with higher-level support or management to explore alternative solutions and keep the customer informed throughout the process.

Conclusion

Your ticket escalation process is essential to the smooth customer experience you should strive to create. By seamlessly passing on problems to



nappy. But this requires a thorough workflow to be in place. By arming agents with greater knowledge and authority, you can reduce escalations, reduce resolution times, and, with a clear priority system in place, you can work through more complex issues in a more streamlined manner.

Speed up ticket escalation

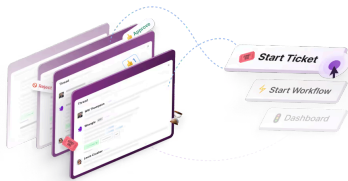
Wrangle is a modern ticketing system built into Slack for convenient and intelligent escalation. With it, you can easily:

- **Automate ticketing:** Instantly convert Slack messages into actionable tickets, complete with critical information.
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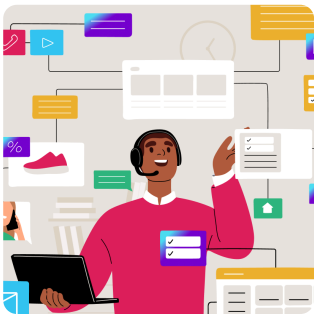


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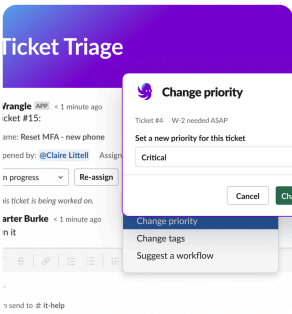


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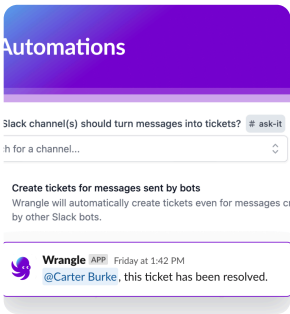


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